

URBAN DELUGE People on a flooded street after torrential rains paralysed Mumbai, Jul. 27, 2005

AFP



◀ *Clockwise from left: Dec. 21, 2009, Sept. 15, 2008, Aug. 8, 2005, Apr. 23, 2007*

From 2005 to 2015, India's engagement with climate change unfolded in a paradoxical arc. It was a decade marked by devastating natural and man-made disasters that repeatedly exposed ecological fragility and administrative unpreparedness, even as the country slowly repositioned itself on the global climate stage from a reluctant participant to a cautious agenda-setter.

The 2005 Mumbai deluge and 2008 Kosi floods were turning points. Extreme rainfall and river breaches became disasters through unplanned urbanisation, ecological damage, ignored warnings and state inertia, exposing how climate vulnerability is magnified by chronic governance failure nationwide.

EXTREME WEATHER EVENTS BECAME DISASTERS THROUGH UNPLANNED URBANISATION, ECOLOGICAL DAMAGE, IGNORED WARNINGS AND STATE INERTIA

The turning point in policy articulation came in 2008 with the launch of the National Action Plan on Climate Change. It marked India's first structured attempt to mainstream climate concerns into development planning. Internationally, India's role evolved sharply around the Copenhagen climate summit in 2009. Initially positioned as a hardliner defending the developing world's right to grow, India gradually shifted towards pragmatic engagement.

Yet, even as climate diplomacy matured, Uttarakhand's 2013 floods and Kashmir's 2014 deluge showed disasters weren't acts of God alone. Climate extremes met reckless construction, tourism, mining and deforestation, while administrative collapse and delayed response paralysed governance, proving India's disaster management remained reactive, not preventive nationwide.

By the mid-2010s, India began embracing renewable energy with unprecedented ambition, particularly solar power. By the 2015 Paris Summit, India had emerged as a confident climate actor, committing to large-scale clean energy expansion while continuing to argue for climate justice. ■